

ELIZA: Does that have anything to do with the fact that your boyfriend made you come here?

As you can see, the conversation is remarkably human, even though it is entirely by an intelligent agent. The success of the chatbot was such that in his subsequent book *Computer Power and Human Reason: From Judgment to Calculation*, Weizenbaum wrote that people became emotionally involved in the conversations with ELIZA. He was asked to leave the room on several occasions, with some test subjects even refusing to let him read the transcripts since it was a private conversation.

Of course, ELIZA is essentially Weak AI, only being able to regurgitate a set of lines that Weizenbaum had fed into it. The scientist himself abandoned the project early, stating that it had accomplished its purpose: proving the viability of a chatbot and figuring out the basis needed for it.

Verbots

The applied science behind ELIZA has become the basis of all research on chatterbots, so the various others that came between ELIZA and Verbots aren't much to write home about. Essentially, they were just ELIZA with a different purpose. In fact, the most popular one of them – PARRY – has been called as “ELIZA with an attitude”.

But in 1990, Dr. Michael Maudlin – founder of the early web search engine Lycos – created a chatterbot called Julia, based on a new program called VerBot (Verbal Robots). It was initially built for an extremely geeky purpose. Maudlin's friend created an online multi-player gaming virtual world and so Julia was made to traverse the text-based game and talk to other people to see how well it would do. Given the vast amounts of sentences it was learning in new conversations, it was hardly remarkable that most people didn't suspect it was a chatbot. Julia would go on to become the official tour guide for the virtual world, as well as assume other short roles.

Eventually, Maudlin decided to show off the full capacities of Julia as a conversational agent. The verbot's job was to go through a virtual world to pick up pieces of information based on keyword inputs, creating a chain of links over time to quickly access any data. Maudlin simply refocused his efforts on creating a similar chatterbot aimed at carrying out such a task on the World Wide Web.

Sylie has often been described as the first intelligent animated virtual human. The conversational agent was capable of talking with a human